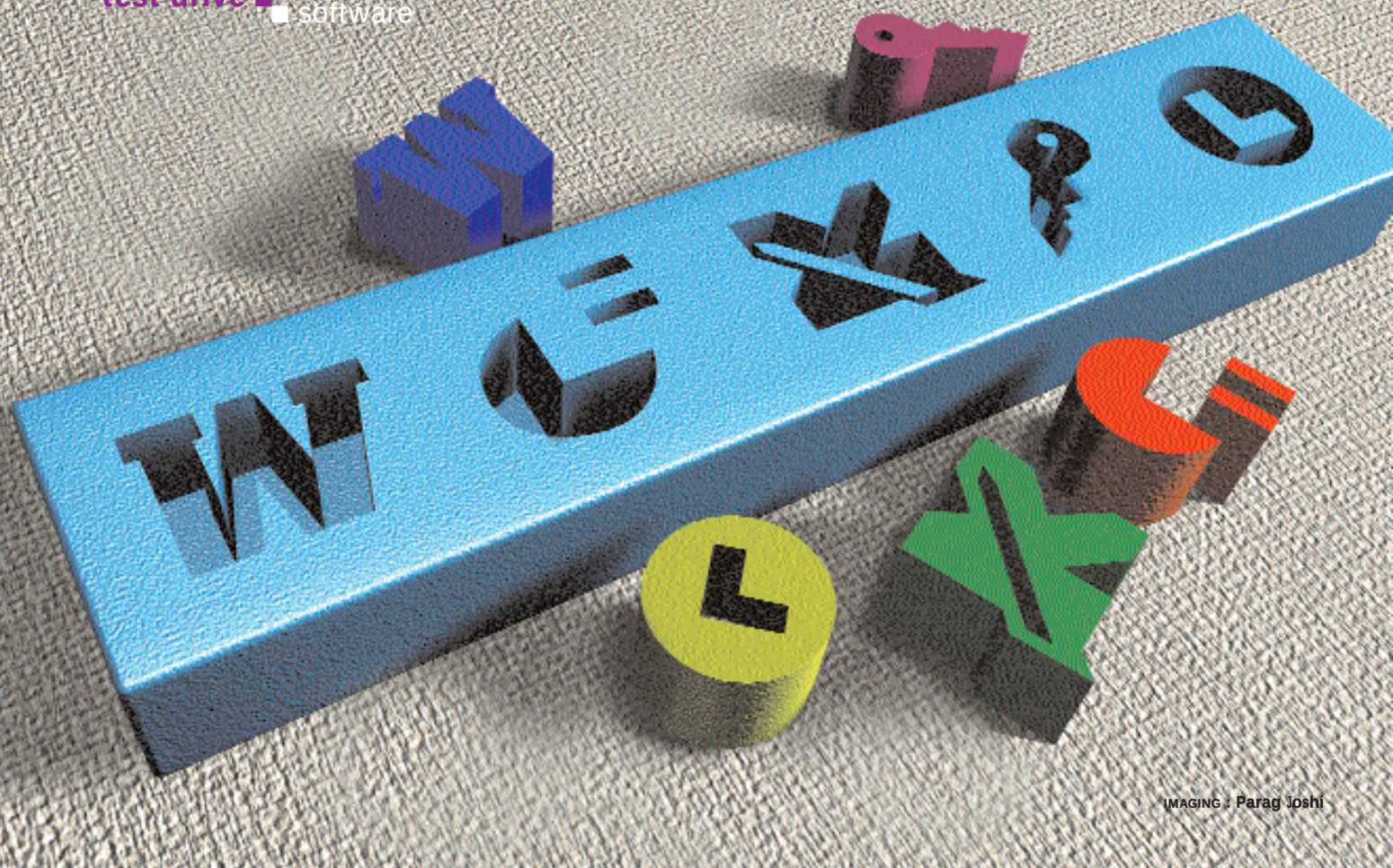




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IN SUITE PURSUIT

You can save a bundle by opting for an alternative to MS Office, but will you be able to exchange files with the MS Office users all around you? We test five of the best Office alternatives for exactly this...

Office productivity applications have an importance that simply can't be ignored. It wouldn't be an overstatement to say that offices can't survive without a decent set of these applications. And the moment you think of office suites, the one that comes to mind is Microsoft Office—the undisputed market leader. Heavy price tag, and frequent upgrade cycles have prompted MS Office users to look at alternatives. Their major concern is the compatibility of these alternatives with the native MS Office file formats of .doc, .ppt, and .xls.

There have always been arguments as to why other office suites should have MS Office compatibility built into them. And while different people have different opinions on this, it's reasonable for organisations and individuals to expect a fair amount of compatibility from

these suites. The reason for this is that even if the native file formats of these applications are superior to those of MS Office, people still have to be able to work with existing office documents, which will, without a doubt, be in MS Office formats.

Our purpose here is to evaluate the level of compatibility offered by various alternative suites with MS Office XP files.

The office suites we picked for this test were the best alternatives to be found currently across multiple operating systems—Windows or Linux, to be precise. A few years ago, this test would not include any Linux office software, because of their rudimentary support for MS Office file formats. But now, with products such as StarOffice and OpenOffice.org coming up on Linux, this is no longer the case. A brief introduction to all the contenders follows:

StarOffice 7: StarOffice 7 is based on the OpenOffice.org project. In the Word documents test, it performed similar to OpenOffice.org; it had the good as well as the bad features. For one, it takes ages to load and keeps on popping up extra untitled documents each time a new document is opened.

OpenOffice.org 1.1.0: OpenOffice.org 1.1, a free downloadable (www.openoffice.org), is a major improvement over previous versions. The current version incorporates several features from StarOffice 7. The results, therefore, were quite similar to what we got with StarOffice 7.

Ability Office: Ability is an office software suite which includes packages that help increase productivity. The said packages include Write, Spreadsheet, Database and Photopaint. Except for the

